



Bid for Air Sahara tickets online at <http://airsahara.indiatimes.com>, and save up to 60 per cent of the airfare most of the times

the Internet for the best deals available, even booking the rooms online.

Shah feels that Indian travel sites still have a long way to go before they can offer the best hotel deals. Most of the deals offered are expensive. There are, however, a few exceptions, such as the decent hotel choices offered by Make My Trip (www.makemytrip.com). For instance, if you want to stay in Mumbai, you can find hotels with fares ranging from Rs 2,200 to Rs 11,000 per night.

Likewise, Indian Hotel Booking (www.india-hotel-booking.com) is a good Web site to check for hotels situated in major cities in India. The Web site has a wide variety of hotels to offer—wild life resorts, ayurveda resorts, spas, heritage hotels, etc.

Some Web sites, cater to hotel accommodations in a particular city. For example, www.hotelsindelihi.net offers hotel rooms in Delhi, www.bangalorehotels.net

lists hotels in Bangalore and www.hotels-mumbai.com for hotels in Mumbai.

Rent a car

So you've decided everything, got your tickets, booked the hotel, arranged for an airport pick-up service, but what do you do once you get there? Taxis in a strange city are always best avoided, unless you have money to burn. Well, you can always hire a car. Travel Jini lets you do so in any of the 50 listed cities. And the rates are affordable too.

Normal full-day rental charges for standard air-conditioned car are as low as Rs 800. Similarly,

Make My Trip helps you rent a car in any of the 30 cities in the country.

One more Web site that offers car rental services is www.carrental-india.com. Here, you can book cars for a trip to any major city. For other cities, you will have to fill an online form and you get a reply with details. Not only does this Web site let you book cars, but also mini coaches, large coaches as well as tempos.

Package deals

The first Web site to check for package deals is Outlook Traveller. Click on a destination,

IRCTC: The virtual reservation counter

We spoke to J Vinayan, Deputy General Manager - Operations, IRCTC. He told us how IRCTC's online reservation module is fast becoming a viable alternative for the Indian traveller.

He says, "We started www.irctc.co.in in August 2002 with around 100 reservations per day. When we started, we delivered tickets only in Delhi. Now we deliver tickets in 111 cities and facilitate more than 3,500 reservations per day." He attributes the increase in the number of online reservations to IRCTC's strategic tie-ups with banks, and of course, an increasing Internet user base.

"When a customer books his

ticket online, he gets other advantages as well. Currently, we are running a special scheme where we refund the booking amount to one customer, every week."

He talks enthusiastically about the future plans of IRCTC, "We will soon introduce a host of add-on services like getting PNR-status alerts via SMS. Then, we will introduce a scheme for corporate bookings and later, we also plan to introduce the facility of booking ticket through mobile phones."

Looks like travelling for those of us with Internet connections is going to become a lot easier in the near future.



Hire a car online at www.carrental-india.com



Traveljini (www.traveljini.com) offers tour packages for national and international destinations. If you are not satisfied with the packages on offer, you can always customise your own

and it will show you the deals available. Make My Trip also has a lot of good packages deals on offer for the Indian traveller. The Web site also lets you customise your package tour according to your preferences.

Travel Jadoo (www.traveljadoo.com) also lists customised holiday packages—you can choose the cities, the routes and the mode of travel.

Get up, and get going

Truly, the Internet has a plethora of addresses that you can knock at to get that perfect idyllic deal. So, go net your spot, pack your bags, and go surf the waves or search for the meaning of life—it's all a few clicks away!

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